

Money Mistake: Your Gym Costs a Fortune

THE FIX: WALK IT OFF

Committing to a healthy lifestyle is crucial at any age, and seniors need to keep active, too, often on tight budgets. When you're thinking about keeping fit, think of your body, but also your pocketbook. By some reports, obesity costs the United States \$190 billion in lost productivity and associated health expenditures. But that would assume that people who need the gym are the ones actually joining, and that's not necessarily the case. People who join gyms are generally into fitness, so the gym is more of a social club than the only means of getting some exercise.

And gyms are expensive social clubs, as well as insidious money pits. Most gym memberships require an up-front registration fee of several hundred dollars, and then a monthly payment that's anywhere from \$30 to \$100 or more, depending on the amenities. So on average, you're paying about \$1,000 a year. Again, worth it if those millions of people were committed, the pounds dropped off, and health care costs plummeted. That'd be a good investment.

But for most people, buying a gym membership is like subscribing to a magazine they never read. Every month, they pay money to a company that provides them with something they pretty much throw away, and they continue to pay for the privilege. According to some reports, four out of five gym memberships go unused after the first three months. That's a significant drop-off, and a big waste of money.

You might be surprised to learn that I don't advocate building a home gym of any kind, either. All those gizmos get thrown under the bed after one or two uses. And a treadmill eventually becomes an expensive clothes hanger in most people's bedrooms, yet they're still making payments on it. So don't get lulled into buying that elliptical because you think you'll save on a gym membership. You're spending the same amount, but on a different useless gadget. If you really want to get fit and save some money, start walking everywhere. I can't stress this alternative enough. In fact, if you live within an hour's walk to work, by leaving the car at home a few times a week, you're getting